

Laura Marshall

Design Systems Leader

Portfolio lauramarshall.design

Contact lauraa.marshall@outlook.com

07531 759 386

Experience

Design Systems & Visual Design Lead

IBM · 2019–present

Design systems · Product design

Seven years at IBM building, contributing to, and driving adoption of the Carbon Design System at scale — while shipping features across enterprise products.

Career highlights include

- Leading a team of 10 designers to build the Carbon for IBM Products Figma kit from scratch — applying Carbon's token architecture, adapting quickly to Figma variables as they launched, defining the roadmap, reviewing all contributions, and shipping 30+ components with **165% adoption growth** in five months.
- Researching design-to-development collaboration across **100+ developers in 12 countries** — identifying the cultural root cause, publishing guidance, and establishing practices that brought design and engineering into shared ownership earlier.
- Leading a team of designers to migrate **8 newly acquired products onto a shared design system in 9 months** — defining the governance model, influencing teams who hadn't chosen the system, and building the compliance framework used to report progress to senior leadership.
- Contributing many components and patterns to Carbon alongside my day job in product — including button guidance, full page errors (identified through an accessibility contrast gap in dark mode), tag overflow and grid influencers — identifying gaps through product work and driving them through the formal contribution process into system-level standards used across IBM.
- Using AI-assisted workflows to contribute HTML and CSS fixes directly into production code — merged into a live IBM product — the first designer in my organisation to bridge design and code this way.
- Designing an AI-driven radiology triage system — filed as a US patent in 2022 — applying machine learning to surface the most critical cases first, before AI tooling was a mainstream conversation in product.
- Building IBM's Product Gallery — making good design visible and reusable across IBM's global design community.
- Mentoring **10+ designers** across my career — on design systems, contribution processes, and visual design craft.

Industry Lecturer

University of Reading · 2019–2025

For six years I led a compulsory second year app design module — covering user-centred design, design thinking, and helping students build design systems for their projects.

Education

First Class – BA Graphic Communication

University of Reading · 2019

Dissertation exploring Braille's relevance alongside emerging technological alternatives — later published as a piece of design research.

Awards

Technical Collaboration Achievement Programme

IBM · 2023, 2024

Recognition for significant contributions to Carbon for IBM Products and the broader open source ecosystem.

Growth Award

IBM · 2022

Recognised for exceptional leadership delivering the Carbon for IBM Products Figma kit — essential to IBM's move to Figma, saving every team from recreating assets from scratch.

Carbon Champion

IBM · 2022, 2024

Recognised twice — for aligning Carbon components and guidance across product teams via the Design System Adoption Guild, and for creating the Product Gallery to foster consistency across IBM's design community.

RockIT Award

IBM · 2019

Best Newcomer. Recognised for a can-do, ask-why mentality and high quality visual design across product and community work.

Patents

Artificial Intelligence Prioritization of Abnormal Radiology Scans

United States Patent Office · 2022

A machine learning system that pre-reads scans, surfaces the most critical image, and prioritises urgent cases by severity — before the radiologist opens anything.

Published research

Braille in an evolving technological world

Visible Language Journal · 2020

Research into people's experiences of Braille as a reading method. Published in the oldest peer-reviewed design journal, with an acceptance rate below 20%.